



Out to prove a point: Former World Championships bronze medallist Lakshya Sen is seeded 14th in men's singles. GETTY IMAGES

But keep an eye out for Sindhu. At 31, she's no longer among the youngest players on the circuit. Her draw is not easy either. Wang Zhi Yi, who has beaten her three times this year, could await in the last 16. Putri Kusuma Wardani, who beat Sindhu at last year's World Championships, is a potential quarterfinal opponent.

The Indian, though, has reasons for optimism. She's coming off a win at the Japan Open Super 750, her biggest title since the 2019 World Championships. She overcame Chen Yufei after the Chinese retired while trailing in the semifinals before beating Akane Yamaguchi in the final. "She looks good in her training, and the best part is that she is able to close the matches that she used to lose earlier," Gopichand says.

The Korean is in Sindhu's half and therefore cannot meet her before the semifinals. A sixth World Championships medal would put

Sindhu in even more exclusive territory. She's never beaten An before, and what better place to do it than in India?

Medal hopes

The loudest support, however, could be reserved for Satwik and Chirag. The question is how quickly Satwik can rediscover his rhythm.

They have had an uneven season. They reached the Swiss Open quarterfinals, the Thailand Open final and then won the Singapore Open in May. Just as they appeared to be gathering momentum, Satwik's shoulder problem resurfaced.

He withdrew from the Indonesia Open and Japan Open, leaving the duo with a period away from competitive badminton immediately before the World Championships.

The injury has been a recurring concern for years. Satwik suffered a shoulder injury in 2018 and has had to manage it ever since.

Coach Tan Kim Her, though, says the Indian is now almost fully recovered. "Satwik is ready now. The rehab is still there, but he's getting

much, much better. Chirag is fully 100 per cent fit," Tan says.

The pair has sacrificed tournament appearances to protect his shoulder and prepare for the World Championships. That should leave them physically fresher than many of their rivals, but it also means they have to regain the competitive rhythm that comes only from playing matches.

"The important part is confidence and whether he can get the rhythm back or not," Tan says.

Their draw gives them a first-round bye and a possible quarterfinal against China's Liang Weikeng and Wang Chang, the Paris Olympic silver medallists. The Indonesian pair Raymond Indra-Nikolaus Joaquin, fresh from reaching the Indonesia Open final, could also pose problems. But men's doubles is wildly unpredictable these days. Korea's world No. 1 pair, Kim Won-ho and Seo Seung-jae, has been in great touch. But they, too, have been beaten by the Indian duo this year. The rest of the field has been remarkably inconsistent.

That's the point coach Tan